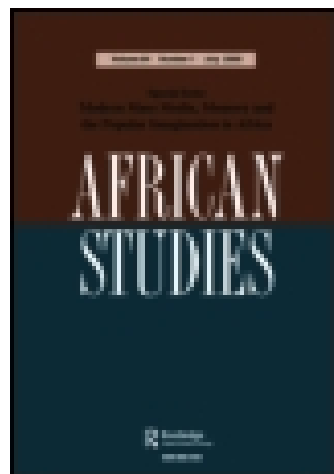


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A NOTE ON LUVALE JOKING RELATIONS

C. M. N. WHITE*

SYNOPSIS

This paper supplements an earlier one¹ on some aspects of Luvale social organization, and is especially intended to remove ambiguities which may be found in the brief reference therein to joking relations. Joking relations are now shown to occur between certain types of kin, but not between members of the same matrilineage. What are primarily joking relations based on kinship are extended into certain friendship relations, and also certain types of clan joking; but there are no paired clan joking relations. Two other types of joking relations are also described. The Luvale have no joking relations with other tribes.

In 1955² I made brief mention of this topic, and questioned whether the Luvale had joking relations in the senses commonly understood. It seems advisable to amplify this subject, since certain features of familiarity and easy relations between individuals in given structural relations would commonly be regarded as typical of joking relations. Kinship provides the most convenient frame of reference for examining these features.

Within the limits of each of the matrilineages which form the most important units of Luvale society no joking relations are found. Here relations are based upon the solidarity of the matrilineage which had important functions in the field of self-help, the feud, and joint responsibility and corporate action on behalf of individual members.³ The absence of joking relations within a matrilineage involves one point of importance; although there is familiarity between alternate generations whose members call each other grandparent and grandchild, this does not apply to members of the same matrilineage. In this instance the grandparents may show some familiarity to their grandchildren but the relation is not symmetrical.

Although the Luvale affirm that a man is succeeded by his sister's son, in practice this

is by no means always the case. Adelpic succession is common and if a series of brothers succeed one another before succession drops to a lower generation, it may happen that grandchildren and not nephews inherit. Although grandparents and grandchildren of the same matrilineage do not distinguish terminologically their special relationship in the way in which Cunnison has shown to occur on the Luapula⁴, their special relationship is indicated by the modified form of joking relations which otherwise apply between alternate generations. Turner, referring to the position among the Ndembu⁵, who are fairly closely related to the Luvale, stresses that grandparent-grandchild relations, in spite of their familiarity, are associated with certain tensions. Among the Luvale these tensions take a clearly defined form, and are chiefly apparent within a matrilineage.

Relationships of familiarity are common in many African societies between members of alternate generations, and are found among the Luvale with the qualification already indicated. Hence persons calling each other grandparent (*kaka*) and grandchild (*muzukulu*) indulge in familiarity provided they are not members of the same matrilineage; all the members of these

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¹ *African Studies*, 14, 3, 1955, pp. 97-112.

² *Op. cit.*, p. 101.

³ Cf. C. M. N. White, *Africa*, Jan. 1957, pp. 59-73.

⁴ Ian Cunnison (1956) "Perpetual kinship: a political institution of the Luapula peoples". *Human Problems in British Central Africa*, 20, pp. 28-48.

⁵ V. W. Turner (1955) "The spatial separation of generations in Ndembu village structure". *Africa*, 25, 2, pp. 121-37.

alternate generations use these terms to refer to each other, and do not otherwise distinguish each other in terminology. Grandparent-grandchild marriages may take place provided that the grandchild is not the child of a man's own child or a child of his sister's child, but such marriages are infrequent, and are socially disapproved. The Luvale say of them that the parties concerned have stabbed each other (*kulitwa poko*).

Joking relations are permitted between Ego and the generation above him in the case of his father's sister or the wife of his mother's brother. These females are known alike as *tatapwevo*, and the husband of a father's sister is called *natu*, the same term applied to a mother's brother. In this relationship there is a marked conflict between asserted norms of conduct and those actually practised. Ego's mother's brother is in a position of special authority over Ego, as I have shown in the earlier paper¹, and respect is required between Ego and his mother's brother. Adultery with the wife of a mother's brother is therefore a very serious matter, and may result in Ego being expelled from the village, or in a split within the village, if it is brought to light. Nevertheless Ego and his mother's brother's wife are on terms of familiarity, and adultery between them is by no means rare, although comparatively rarely disclosed. In the case of the Luchazi it is often alleged that wife-lending between a mother's brother and his nephew is quite usual, and is explained on the ground that the nephew is likely to inherit his mother's brother's wife, and is merely anticipating the time. Widow inheritance is not regular among the Luvale however, and the two societies differ in this respect, but clandestine relations with a mother's brother's wife are none the less not rare.

Within the same generation a well marked form of joking relation exists between persons calling each other cross-cousin (*musonyi*). Cross-cousin marriages were a preferred form of marriage among the Luvale, although today many young men dislike them because they complain that they are difficult to

dissolve. This preferred form of marriage is reflected in kinship terminology; the husband of a female cross-cousin is called "the one of whom I am jealous" (*muka lisungu lyami*); the wife of a male cross-cousin is 'sister-in-law'. In the latter relationship of brother- and sister-in-law joking occurs, but not in the case of the husband of a female cross-cousin. Free sexual relations between cross-cousins are normal, and a man can always sleep with his cross-cousin if he wants to. But adultery with a cross-cousin married to another man is regarded as worse than casual adulteries with unrelated persons. It is argued that X could have married the woman if he had wanted her, and should leave her alone if she has been left to be married by another man. In addition X is identified with his mother's brother in this situation; the latter, as father of the girl has taken a bride-price which his nephew as possible heir may in theory if not in fact inherit. Thus X is considered to have profited out of the girl's marriage to another, but still continues to have access to her.

It is important in this connection to note that the Luvale treat extra-marital relations of an adulterous nature comparatively lightly. A Luvale girl at her puberty rites is not instructed to avoid infidelity, but to avoid being found out, especially in situations in which kinship relations are involved. It is assumed that she will have lovers, but the consequences of being found out in certain kinship contexts are stressed. In the instruction at her puberty rites, these relationships are referred to when she is told "If your father-in-law wants to sleep with you, do not tell anyone".

No joking relations occur between Ego and the generation immediately below him; his relatives in this generation are described as either *mwana* (child) or *mwiha* (nephew or niece). His position in respect of both types of classificatory relation is one of authority demanding reciprocal respect.

A further form of joking relation which requires comment is found between persons calling each other *nyali* (brother-in-law,

¹ White (1955).

sister-in-law). Sororal polygyny is not found among the Luvale, and X, although he may joke with his wife's sister, should not have sexual relations with her. To do so is said to be likely to lead to the break-up of his marriage because he is likely to find her more attractive than her sister to whom he is married. In fact, judging by the number of men who admit to having such relations, men often sleep clandestinely with their wives' sisters.

A paradoxical situation arises when X has a brother; this brother is *nyali* to the sister of X's wife, and not only jokes with her, but has freedom of access to her sexually. Unless the woman is married, no stigma attaches to such relations and people say of X's brother that the sister of X's wife is his wife, and naturally sleeps with him. Nevertheless it is considered most undesirable for two brothers to marry two sisters, and such marriages almost always denote a slave origin of the women. Marriage between persons calling each other *nyali* is therefore disapproved but sexual relations between them are common except where there is a sibling relationship described as *yaya* (younger brother or sister) or *songo* (younger brother or sister) involved. A person should not have adulterous relations with the sibling of his own spouse, nor with the spouse of his own sibling.

Ego calls the wife of a male cross-cousin *nyali*: here a joking relation is doubled since it exists between Ego and his cross-cousin, and between Ego and his *nyali*. Adultery between Ego and the wife of his cross-cousin is a small matter, not normally leading to any legal consequences, and settled amicably between the parties concerned without compensation.

Joking relations between kin among the Luvale fall into the categories which have been described above. In every case there is primarily a joking relation between persons with a given structural relationship between them described by certain fixed terms. But in each case there are certain modifications in the joking relation which may arise from the specific nature of the genealogical links between the persons concerned. Classi-

ficatory kinship terminology is not an absolute yardstick by which to measure the presence or extent of joking relations. Where such terminology applies the Luvale do not accept the proposition that joking relations between certain specified kin are a feature of their society, since they find it necessary to qualify the nature and extent of such joking relations in each instance. In their fullest form they see joking relations equated with freedom of sexual relations, and it is especially in this field that the extent of classificatory terminology and its attendant joking relations is liable to be modified by genealogical considerations. Social distance between kin is not merely a matter of terminological usage, even though terminology does not assist in indicating social distance.

* * *

We may now turn to an extension of joking relations in fields outside kinship. The Luvale are greatly given to forming friendships of a voluntary nature outside the limits of their kin, and they designate these friendships by using kinship terminology especially associated with joking relations between kin. In the most intimate cases they like to call each other *musonyi* (cross-cousin), and the Luvale say that a woman sleeping with a lover invariably addresses him as her *musonyi*. Equally common but perhaps a little less intimate is the use of *nyali* between such friends. On the other hand such friends do not use the terminology of the grandparent-grandchild relationship to address each other although familiarity exists in this relationship. Nor do friends use the sibling terms of *yaya* and *songo* as a mark of familiarity between each other. Thus far the usage between friends corresponds to the most robust form of joking relationship between kin. But an important exception occurs. The Luvale avoid parents-in-law, and the latter avoid sons- or daughters-in-law. Nevertheless *tatawenu* (father-in-law, son-in-law) is used between close friends in the same way as *musonyi* and *nyali*, so that a term implying avoidance becomes a term of endearment. This appears

to be logical; avoidance between parents-in-law and children-in-law obviates conflict, just as familiarity between other types of kin is equated with an obligation not to enter into conflict. Friends of a particularly close nature should not engage in conflicts, and either type of kinship terminology is therefore applicable between them, but not the other forms of kinship terminology. Other terms may be used between unrelated persons without any implication of familiarity; thus a man may respectfully address an old man as *kaka* (grandparent); a man may address a younger man with words of good advice and call him *songo* (my young brother). But the use of kinship terms in such extensions as these are contrasted sharply with the use of other terms between close friends. Standardized forms of social relationships are thus fused into a single system applicable both to relatives and unrelated persons. Only within the matrilineage is there unity and solidarity in which no place exists for these variations in social attitudes. A person's joking relations with other members of his own matrilineage are thus contrasted with those he has with non-members with whom he may be on special terms of familiarity either through marriage links or through specific voluntary friendships.

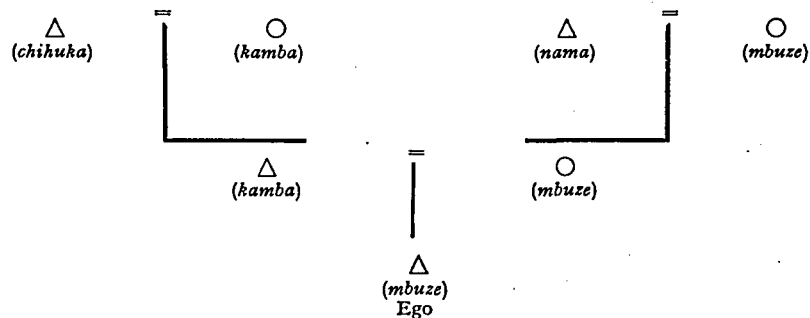
At this stage it is necessary to examine the nature of joking relations between the Luvale clans. I have already discussed features of the Luvale clans¹, and for the present it is only necessary to point out that they are equivalent to maximal matrilineages

of a fictitious nature since their members are dispersed, and cannot trace genealogical links with one another apart from those established within their actual matrilineages. Unlike many Central African tribes, the Luvale have no reciprocal joking relations between paired clans, and no reciprocal funerary friendships based upon paired clans. Since the clans are exogamous, joking relations do not occur between members of a single clan except where they arise from voluntary friendships between clansmen who cannot establish a genealogical link with each other. Clan membership like matrilineage membership is primarily a matter of unity and solidarity.

A man may, however, have joking relations with other clans arising out of his kinship links to them. This may be illustrated from the genealogy below, on which the names shown are clan-names.

In this genealogy Ego is a member of the *mbuze* clan; he looks for help first to his matrilineage and its extension of other *mbuze* clansmen; secondly to the members of the father's matrilineage, and its extension of other *kamba* clansmen; thirdly to the matrilineage of his mother's father, and its extension of other *nama* clansmen. He does not look for help to the members of the *chihuka* clan, his father's father's matrilineage.

In the case of other *mbuze* clansmen, his right of assistance is automatic and he does not joke with them; in the case of members of the *nama* and *kamba* clans his right to assistance is secondary, and he says: "The



¹ White (1955 and 1956).

nama begot my mother and the *kamba* bore my father". Ego jokes with members of these two clans on this ground. He neither jokes with nor expects help from *chihuka* clansmen.

These joking relations with members of the *kamba* and *nama* clans do not take precedence over the relationships between Ego and kinsmen as enjoyed within the limits of actual genealogical kinship. Thus Ego says: "I joke with members of the *kamba* clan because they bore my father, but not with those relatives whom I cannot be the nature of their relationship joke with, even though they are *kambas*. Similarly although I do not joke with the *chihukas* as a clan because they are too remote, I do joke with those *chihukas* whom I term *kaka* (grandparent) on my father's side".

These inter-clan joking relations thus arise out of actual genealogical links which are projected into the fictitious kinship of the clans; they are not in any way determined by any regular pairing of clans on a reciprocal basis such as occurs among e.g. the Bemba or Ambo. By this means the duty of help between clansmen is none the less extended to cases where persons are members of different clans which establish a claim to mutual aid arising from actual genealogical links, so that Ego can mobilize a much wider range of support that would be afforded solely by his own matrilineage and his own clan members. Since the Luvale clans are widely dispersed and occur also among the Chokwe and Luchazi, and since, as I have shown¹, the Luvale have been characterized by great mobility, such inter-clan joking relations must have been of great importance to a man operating away from his own kinsmen or clansmen. At the same time the joking relations between clans no doubt served a useful purpose in maintaining social control. A man's own clan is essentially a unitary group taking action on behalf of its own members against others, so that one might in the case of feuds envisage one clan being pitted against another. The inter-clan joking relations must have served to mitigate such conflicts, and helped to organize a

stable social system outside the limits of separate matrilineages or their fictitious extension to common clan membership.

The type of inter-clan joking relations thus established manifests itself in ways often similar to those existing between members of reciprocal clans with such joking relations. Thus if Ego dies, clansmen with whom he joked might jokingly ask members of his own matrilineage which of them was responsible for his death, since sorcery is believed to operate mainly within a matrilineage.

It is important to stress that these inter-clan joking relations arise in the first instance from actual genealogical links since the Luvale themselves see no resemblance between them and the joking relations between reciprocal paired clans, and if asked whether they have inter-clan joking relationships like the Ambo or Bemba, promptly deny that they do.

* * *

There are two other types of joking relations which should be briefly noted; neither arises from either kinship or voluntary friendship. Persons born on the same day joke together; they know of their birth on the same day primarily because they live in the same village or sufficiently near for other older persons to be able to tell them that they were so born. Joking partners of this type indulge in robust familiarity but are not particularly numerous.

A milder type of joking relation occurs between people who share the same name. Each calls the other *muka lijina lyami* (one of my name). Joking relations between persons of the same name are not automatic. They depend upon a similarity in age between the parties. A much younger man does not joke thus with an older man even though their names happen to be the same.

* * *

Joking relations in Central Africa occur in a further form between pairs of tribes. Thus the Bemba joke with the Ngoni, and the Lozi with the Ila. The Luvale have no

¹ White (1956).

inter-tribal joking relations of this type. It is commonly held that inter-tribal joking relations have originated from a history of hostility between tribes concerned, especially where the hostility took the form of rivalry rather than raiding on the one hand, or a fight for existence on the other. Although the Luvale live in proximity to the Chokwe, Luchazi, Mbunda and Lunda, and all are closely related tribes, and their relations with each other have frequently been hostile, the hostility has mainly been manifested in raiding for slaves, and not in actual warfare or in balanced rivalry. The point is of some interest in connection with the Lunda-Luvale "war" at the end of the last century.

Both Lunda and Luvale are inclined to make much of this war, and point out that according to tradition the Lunda had to call upon Lozi help to avoid annihilation. But when one presses the history of the episode it becomes remarkably difficult to find any real issue over which the war was fought. I have little doubt that it was no more than part of the series of raids for slaves which the Luvale indulged in continuously against

their Lunda neighbours. It has certainly left no inter-tribal joking relation behind it.

To-day the Luvale sometimes find in urban areas that the Kaonde claim an inter-tribal joking relation with them. They point out that they never had any close relations with the Kaonde in the past to have given rise to such a relation, and only came in contact at all on scanty occasions when Luvale slave raiders pushed as far east as the Kaonde. They consider that the Kaonde claim a joking relation to-day on account of coming from the same north-western part of Northern Rhodesia as the Luvale, because they have seen inter-tribal joking relations in towns between other pairs of tribes who have some geographical proximity.

The Luvale thus do have a form of joking relation founded primarily upon the kinship structure which may be extended outside strict kinship into links between persons established through clans or friendship. The brief reference in my earlier paper¹ may be thought misleading without further amplification which is now provided in the foregoing discussion.

SURVEYS BY I.F.A.N.²

The Inter-African Committee on Social Sciences (C.C.T.A.-C.S.A.), Paris, reports on two related surveys at present being conducted in the Lower Ivory Coast by the Institut Français d'Afrique Noire.

The first and more comprehensive is a study of migration which supplements one made a year ago and coincides with similar surveys of migration being made in Ghana and in the First Agricultural Sector of the Ivory Coast. It will comprise a systematic census over a year of migrants using the Bonaké road with sample polls relating to migrants' family status, former journeys, motives and religious and political affiliations and attitudes. Between the peak periods of

migration, i.e. during the workers' seasonal stay in the Basse-Côte, complementary ethnographic and sociological studies will be carried out on, for instance, plantation labour, particular ethnic groups among the migrants and the economic causes and implications of the migration.

The second survey is of the Abidjan markets and comprises (a) a study of trends in licences issued; (b) a brief census of pedlars followed by more detailed sample studies of their origins, visits to the Basse-Côte, the nature of their businesses, their stock and their prices; (c) a study of localization and specialization in the urban markets and the emergence of new markets.

¹ White (1955).

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